

Chapter 10 – Staff Authorization, Staff Identification Numbers (SSID), and Tax Agents

10.1 Introduction

The Inland Revenue Department (IRD) allows taxpayers to authorize other persons to carry out tax-related activities on their behalf through the IRD e-Services Portal. This feature is particularly useful for companies, partnerships, and businesses that require employees or professional tax agents to prepare tax documents and manage tax matters.

To ensure security and accountability, the IRD provides an authorization system that uses **Staff Identification Numbers (SSID)** and **Tax Agent Authorizations**. Different levels of access can be assigned depending on the responsibilities of the authorized individual.

10.2 What is Staff Authorization?

Staff Authorization is the process by which a company or organization grants permission to an employee to perform tax-related activities on its behalf using the IRD e-Services Portal.

Only authorized staff members can access company tax records and perform the activities assigned to them.

Authorization is completed electronically through the IRD e-Services Portal.

10.3 What is a Staff Identification Number (SSID)?

A **Staff Identification Number (SSID)** is a unique identification number issued by the Inland Revenue Department to employees who are authorized to access the IRD e-Services Portal on behalf of a company or registered tax agent.

The SSID allows employees to log in securely and perform tax-related tasks without using the company's own login credentials.

Companies and registered tax agents can request SSIDs through the IRD e-Services Portal.

10.4 Who Can Request an SSID?

According to the IRD guidelines, SSIDs may be requested by:

- Registered Companies
- Registered Partnerships
- Registered Tax Agents

Individuals who manage only their own tax matters do not require an SSID.

10.5 Requesting Staff IDs (SSID)

Companies and registered tax agents can request Staff Identification Numbers through the IRD e-Services Portal.

The general process is:

1. Log in to the IRD e-Services Portal.
2. Navigate to **Authorisation**.
3. Select **Request SSID**.
4. Enter the number of Staff IDs required.
5. Submit the request.
6. Receive an acknowledgement confirming the request.

The IRD sends the approved SSIDs and their initial passwords to the registered postal address. Companies may request **up to 20 SSIDs** through the portal.

10.6 Activating Staff IDs

After receiving the SSID, it must be activated before use.

The activation process includes:

1. Log in to the IRD e-Services Portal.
2. Select **Authorisation → Change Staff Password**.
3. Enter the SSID.
4. Enter the employee's National Identity Card (NIC) number.
5. Issue the password.
6. Record the generated password.

During the employee's first login, the system requires the password to be changed for security purposes.

10.7 Authorizing Company Staff

After activating an SSID, the company must authorize the employee to perform tax-related activities.

The authorization process generally includes:

1. Log in to the IRD e-Services Portal.
2. Select **Authorisation → Create Staff Authorization**.
3. Enter the employee's TIN or SSID.
4. Search for the employee.
5. Select the applicable tax types.
6. Specify the authorization period.
7. Assign the employee's role.
8. Save the authorization request.

The system generates an acknowledgement confirming the authorization.

10.8 Staff Roles

The IRD provides two authorization roles for company staff.

Preparer

A **Preparer** may:

- Prepare tax returns.
- Save tax returns as drafts.
- Edit draft submissions.

A Preparer **cannot submit** tax returns to the IRD.

Approver

An **Approver** has all the permissions of a Preparer and may also:

- Review prepared returns.
- Submit returns to the Inland Revenue Department.

Organizations should assign these roles carefully to ensure appropriate internal controls.

10.9 Authorizing Tax Agents

Instead of authorizing internal staff, taxpayers may authorize a registered tax agent to manage their tax matters.

The authorization process includes:

1. Log in to the IRD e-Services Portal.
2. Select **Authorisation → Create Tax Agent Authorization**.
3. Enter the Tax Agent's TIN.
4. Search for the registered tax agent.
5. Select the relevant tax types.
6. Specify the effective period.
7. Save the authorization.

Unlike company staff, **tax agents are assigned only the Preparer role**. They may prepare tax submissions but cannot submit them on behalf of the taxpayer.

10.10 Registering as a Tax Agent

Individuals or partnerships wishing to act as tax agents must first register with the Inland Revenue Department.

Applicants must:

- Already possess a valid TIN.
- Meet one of the qualifications recognized by the IRD.
- Submit the required supporting documents.

Recognized qualifications include:

- Attorney-at-Law
 - Member of the Institute of Chartered Accountants of Sri Lanka
 - Member of the Sri Lanka Institute of Taxation
 - Registered Auditor approved under the applicable regulations
 - Any other category approved by the Commissioner General of Inland Revenue (CGIR).
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10.11 Supporting Documents for Tax Agent Registration

Applicants should provide:

- National Identity Card (NIC) or Passport.
- Documentary proof of professional qualifications.
- Supporting evidence demonstrating eligibility to act as a tax agent.

Additional documentation may be requested by the Inland Revenue Department during the registration process.

10.12 Viewing and Managing Authorizations

The IRD e-Services Portal allows organizations and tax agents to manage existing authorizations.

Users may:

- Search for authorized staff.
- View all active authorizations.
- Modify authorization details.
- Terminate authorizations when staff members leave or no longer require access.

Keeping authorization records up to date helps maintain account security.

10.13 Security Considerations

Organizations should:

- Authorize only trusted individuals.
- Assign the minimum level of access required.

- Remove authorizations when no longer needed.
- Protect SSID passwords from unauthorized access.
- Ensure staff change their initial passwords during first login.
- Review active authorizations periodically.

10.14 Common Issues

Issue	Possible Solution
Staff cannot log in	Verify that the SSID has been activated and authorized.
Staff not appearing in search	Confirm the correct TIN or SSID was entered.
Tax Agent cannot access taxpayer records	Ensure the taxpayer has completed the Tax Agent Authorization process.
Forgotten SSID password	The company or registered tax agent can issue a new password through the IRD e-Services Portal.
Authorization expired	Create a new authorization or extend the authorization period as required.

10.15 Key Points

- Companies and registered tax agents can authorize employees to perform tax-related activities.
- Authorized employees receive a **Staff Identification Number (SSID)**.
- Staff must be authorized before accessing company tax records.
- The **Preparer** role allows users to prepare returns but not submit them.
- The **Approver** role allows users to prepare and submit returns.
- Registered tax agents must satisfy IRD qualification requirements before providing tax

services.

- Organizations should regularly review and manage staff and tax agent authorizations to maintain security and compliance.